

The Missing Photo

It was DC 2020-During Corona 2020. The Sharma family was seated in the drawing room, totally **absorbed in** their respective devices, when Mr Sharma's mother, called Granny by all, including her son, **padded** into the room like a cautious cat. Her movements may have been **feline**, but her voice **resembled** the **roar** of a lion.

"Missing!" she announced, **sounding** like a **sergeant** major calling his soldiers to attention. Her hands held behind her back, she gave a general **sweeping glance**.

Five **startled** pairs of eyes looked up from their phones and laptops.

"W...what's missing?" Mr Sharma, who had been **intent** on his work, gave a visible start and his laptop banged shut. "Granny, do you have to **frighten** us like this?"

"Who's missing?" Aditi looked at her grandmother with questioning eyes. She was surprisingly **unruffled**. Ever since she had joined college the previous year, she had been practising at being a **dignified** young lady, no matter what happened.

"Missing? Cool" Arjit, Aditi's older brother, a medical student and an **avid** reader of crime thrillers, **whistled in appreciation**. "Who knows, the dead body will be discovered in a **gunny sack**. Just what we need to break the **monotony**. Let's start with the most important question. Who's missing, Granny?"

"Don't be so **morbid**!" Mrs Sharma **admonished** her son, "What's it, Granny?"

I know, I know, I know!" **chanted** Anita, jumping up and clapping her hands. At nine, she was the baby of the family. She trilled, "It's the chocolates that Granny eats in secret. Arjit ate them all."

"Rubbish!" Both Arjit and Granny responded to this double disclosure with **indignation**. Granny, a diabetic, looked **alarmed**. If she didn't act fast, there would be trouble. **Without further ado**, she showed them what she had behind her back.

It was a photo album.

"An album!" Arjit was disappointed. "How can there be a dead body now?"

"A photo is missing!" Granny **pronounced**.



"That's it?" Mr Sharma **clicked his tongue**. "Just a photo missing and you shouted as if someone had **made away with** your gold. Just as I was getting ready for an important meeting! Really, Granny!" He took his laptop and **stormed off** to his room.

"Which photo is missing?" asked Anita, **snatching** the album from her grandmother's hand. She began flicking through the album. Her **siblings** joined her.

"That's exactly what I'd like to know," said Granny, looking **stern**. "This is our random pictures album, so it'd be very difficult to identify the photo that has been taken."

"And why, and who took it," added Arjit. If this was a mystery, he was **determined** it should be a proper mystery.

A few months back, Granny had placed four albums on the table in the drawing room. Granny had been most disapproving when phones became cameras and photos remained hidden inside devices. She decided to make the family recall the **charms** of physical photos and had chosen four albums for the purpose.

Three of the albums had photos arranged in an organised way. The oldest album had photos of Mr and Mrs Sharma's wedding, followed by pictures of Arjit from the time he was a baby. The other two began with Anita as a baby, and went on to include other photos — birthdays, weddings of cousins, vacations, School Day programmes, the garden, Granny's cooking experiments and so on.

The fourth album was different — it contained **assorted** pictures. Doubles, out-of-focus photos, pictures that caught one on the wrong foot, candid shots, photos of **stray acquaintances**... all had wound their quiet way into it.

Granny's **ploy** worked. Often, someone would look through an album, passing remarks that would **draw** the others into a discussion about the events captured in the pictures. The photos became great conversation starters and the family had a lot of fun **reliving the past**.

But slowly, the albums got ignored. And one day, they disappeared from the table and nobody missed them.

When COVID-19 came, bringing lockdown **in its wake**, the dependence on electronic gadgets became complete. Though the family was at home, everyone was too busy **peering** into screens. Only Granny and Mrs Sharma could be **overheard** arguing over menus and housekeeping. Mechanical responses became the new normal:

"Come for breakfast."

"Lunch is ready."

"Time for dinner."

"Heard you!"

Mrs Sharma began to look **careworn**. Granny became quiet and all were stressed out; this new kind of life was **taking its toll**.

Initially, everyone dismissed the missing photo as a **trivial** issue, but slowly it began to play on their minds.

"What photo could that be?" Arjit was **intrigued**. "I think there was the picture of Dad sleeping on stage, at a function. Dad, did you destroy it?"

"Of course not!" protested Mr Sharma at the same time when Anita, who was looking through the album, **yelled**, "No! It is here."

To Mr Sharma's **embarrassment**, the album was **promptly** passed around.

"What a totally **random** arrangement!" Aditi, the refined lady, **stuck her nose up**. "The photo before the missing one is a blurred one of Ma and Dad, the one after is of a dead rat. The next has a **headless** Anita getting a prize and..."

"Yes, I'm **foxed**. Which photo is missing?" Arjit interrupted her. "And don't forget the all-important question: who took it?"

Everyone **protested** their **innocence** and looked at one another **warily**.

Suspicion also fell on relatives, friends and others who had visited the house before the lockdown.

"Remember Radha Bai came here six months ago and wanted a picture of me as a baby?" Aditi **recalled**. "She was looking through the albums. She might have taken it."

"But you were such an ugly baby!" Anita **giggled**. "Why would anyone want your baby photo?"

"She looked after me when I was a child," Aditi **snapped**.

"I gave her a photo," Mrs Sharma smiled.

"And Aditi's yuck picture is still here, haha," Anita, who had **snatched** the album back from her sister, **pointed to** the photo and **hooted**.

The family started looking through the photos again and each person had new comments to make and fresh incidents to recall. **Nostalgic reminiscences** brought them all together and they spent a lot of time talking and laughing.



Granny once again became an important person for, as the oldest member, everyone appealed to her when their memories **let** them **down**. Granny began to look **cheerful** and healthy. In fact, the whole family began to look happier even though the mystery remained unsolved.

A photo of their parents in the kitchen encouraged Aditi and Arjit to experiment with cooking. **Strange** and often tasteless dishes began to appear on the table as the two began trying out recipes from **tattered** cookery books.

After breakfast one Sunday, as the rest of the family sat in the drawing room, Aditi went off to the kitchen to prepare lunch. In a short while, she returned, looking excited.

"I found IT!" she **squealed**, waving a photo like a flag.

"What!" Arjit **leaped up**. Anita rushed to snatch it. Aditi held her hand aloft and said "I remember this picture. Do you?" She **dangled** the photo like a carrot before Anita.



"Enough, Aditi, let's see the photo," Mr Sharma appealed. "Where was it?"

"Under a newspaper at the bottom of the shelf where Granny keeps her gardening and needlework books. I was **rummaging** there, hoping to find a long-forgotten recipe book, and a corner of this photo peeped out."

"So, Granny, it was you!" Mr Sharma raised his eyebrows. "But why? And show the photo, Aditi."

"You'll never guess," Aditi **grinned** and displayed the photo.

It was a **distorted** image of a shoe flower.

"This one!" Anita made a face.

"All the **fuss** for this!" Arjit laughed. "**Bathos**."

"But I never took the photo from the album," Granny protested. "I saw the album lying on the floor the other day and while looking through it, I saw the missing picture and came to tell—"

"So **whodunit**?" Arjit asked, looking at each one in turn.

"It was me," Mrs Sharma **confessed**, looking rather **sheepish**. "I thought the missing photo would create an interest in the album and that would bring laughter back into this house."

"And it did. Great idea, Ma!" Arjit **chuckled**. "You should have been a psychologist."

Granny didn't say anything. She **merely** looked very happy.

Vocabulary

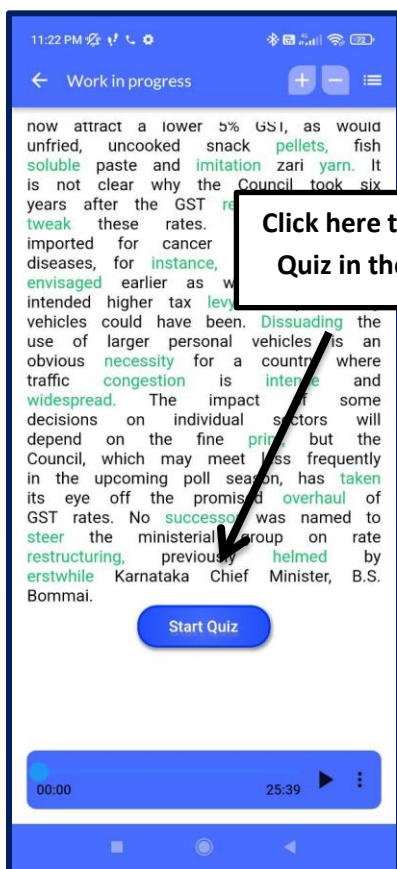
1. **Absorb** (in) (verb) – engross, immerse, involve, engage, captivate – में डूब जाना
2. **Pad** (verb) – walk softly, tiptoe, tread lightly, creep, amble – धीरे चलना
3. **Feline** (noun) – cat, mouser, tom, kitty, tabby – बिल्ली
4. **Resemble** (verb) – look like, mirror, match, simulate, echo – जैसा दिखना
5. **Roar** (noun) – shout, bellow, yell, howl, growl – गरज
6. **Sound** (verb) – declare, pronounce, utter, proclaim, announce – घोषणा करना
7. **Sergeant** (noun) – officer, commander, inspector, constable, enforcer – हवलदार
8. **Sweeping** (adjective) – wide, broad, extensive, comprehensive, overarching – व्यापक
9. **Glance** (noun) – peek, glimpse, look, gaze, scan – झलक
10. **Startled** (adjective) – shocked, surprised, alarmed, stunned, agitated – चौंका हुआ
11. **Intent** (on) (adjective) – focused, determined, absorbed, concentrated, fixed – ध्यान केंद्रित
12. **Frighten** (verb) – scare, terrify, startle, alarm, unnerve – डराना
13. **Unruffled** (adjective) – calm, composed, serene, tranquil, unbothered – शांत
14. **Dignified** (adjective) – respectable, stately, noble, graceful, majestic – गरिमामयी
15. **Avid** (adjective) – enthusiastic, eager, ardent, devoted, passionate – उत्साही
16. **Whistle** (verb) – blow, trill, hoot, chirp, sing – सीटी बजाना
17. **Appreciation** (noun) – admiration, gratitude, recognition, respect, regard – सराहना
18. **Gunny** (adjective) – sackcloth, jute-based, coarse, rough, burlap – बोरे जैसा
19. **Sack** (noun) – bag, pouch, tote, satchel, bundle – बोरा
20. **Monotony** (noun) – dullness, boredom, repetitiveness, sameness, routine – एकरसता
21. **Morbid** (adjective) – gloomy, grim, macabre, dark, unhealthy – रोगग्रस्त/भयानक
22. **Admonish** (verb) – warn, reprimand, scold, rebuke, criticize – डांटना
23. **Chant** (verb) – repeat, recite, sing, intone, hum – जाप करना
24. **Indignation** (noun) – anger, resentment, outrage, fury, annoyance – आक्रोश

25. **Alarmed** (adjective) – worried, disturbed, anxious, scared, fearful – घबराया हुआ
26. **Without further ado** (phrase) – immediately, promptly, without delay, straightaway, forthwith – और देरी के बिना
27. **Pronounce** (verb) – declare, announce, proclaim, utter, express – घोषित करना
28. **Click one's tongue** (phrase) – show disapproval, express annoyance, tut, sigh, scoff – जीभ चटकाना (नाराज़गी दिखाना)
29. **Make away with** (phrase) – steal, escape with, rob, run off with, snatch – चुराकर भाग जाना
30. **Storm off** (phrasal verb) – leave angrily, stomp out, walk out, rush away, flounce – गुस्से में निकल जाना
31. **Snatch** (verb) – grab, seize, clutch, yank, pluck – झपटना
32. **Sibling** (noun) – brother/sister, kin, relation, family member, relative – भाई/बहन
33. **Stern** (adjective) – strict, harsh, severe, serious, tough – कठोर
34. **Determined** (adjective) – resolute, steadfast, unwavering, purposeful, focused – दृढ़ निश्चयी
35. **Charm** (noun) – appeal, allure, attraction, fascination, magic – आकर्षण
36. **Assorted** (adjective) – mixed, various, diverse, miscellaneous, eclectic – विविध
37. **Stray** (adjective) – random, scattered, isolated, lost, accidental – इधर-उधर भटका हुआ
38. **Acquaintance** (noun) – associate, contact, colleague, companion, friend – जान-पहचान वाला
39. **Ploy** (noun) – strategy, tactic, trick, ruse, manoeuvre – चाल
40. **Draw** (verb) – attract, bring, entice, pull, engage – खींचना
41. **Relive the past** (phrase) – remember again, recall, go back in time, reflect, reminisce – अतीत को दोबारा जीना
42. **In its wake** (phrase) – as a result, following, after, in consequence, due to – के बाद
43. **Peer** (verb) – look, glance, gaze, scrutinize, peek – झांकना
44. **Overheard** (adjective) – accidentally heard, listened unintentionally, caught, eavesdropped – अनजाने में सुना गया
45. **Careworn** (adjective) – tired, weary, haggard, anxious, burdened – चिंतित/थका हुआ

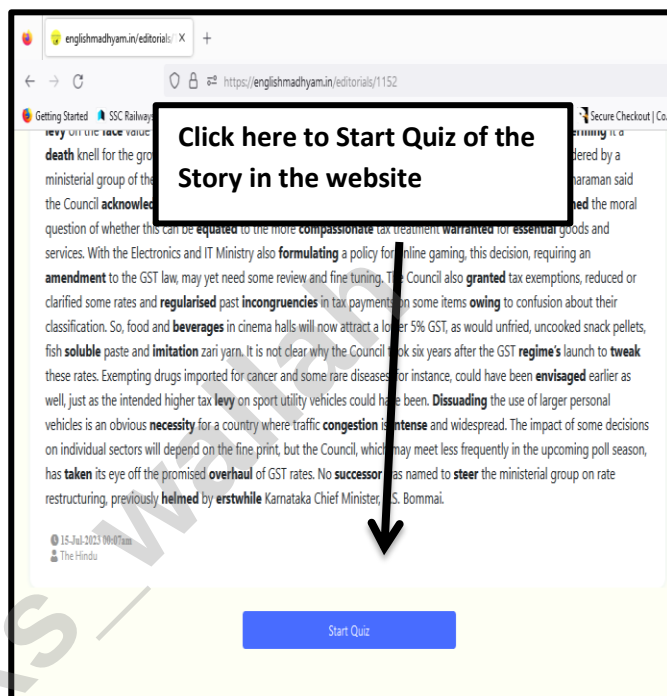
46. **Take one's toll** (phrase) – cause damage, affect badly, wear down, exhaust, harm – असर डालना
47. **Trivial** (adjective) – insignificant, unimportant, petty, minor, small – तुच्छ
48. **Intrigue** (verb) – fascinate, interest, puzzle, attract, arouse curiosity – उत्सुकता जगाना
49. **Yell** (verb) – shout, scream, cry, bellow, holler – चिल्लाना
50. **Embarrassment** (noun) – shame, awkwardness, discomfort, humiliation, unease – शर्मिंदगी
51. **Promptly** (adverb) – quickly, immediately, swiftly, straightaway, instantly – तुरंत
52. **Random** (adjective) – arbitrary, haphazard, unplanned, unmethodical, aimless – बेतरतीब
53. **Stick one's nose up** (phrase) – act superior, look down, snub, scorn, disregard – घमंड दिखाना
54. **Headless** (adjective) – without a head, incomplete, decapitated, defective, unfinished – सिर रहित
55. **Foxed** (adjective) – confused, puzzled, baffled, stumped, bewildered – उलझन में पड़ा
56. **Protest one's innocence** (phrase) – deny guilt, claim innocence, insist on innocence, defend, plead – अपनी बेगुनाही की सफाई देना
57. **Warily** (adjective) – cautiously, suspiciously, carefully, doubtfully, alertly – संदेहपूर्वक
58. **Recall** (verb) – remember, recollect, call to mind, bring back, reflect – याद करना
59. **Giggle** (verb) – laugh, chuckle, snicker, titter, snigger – दबी हंसी हँसना
60. **Snap** (verb) – reply sharply, retort, bark, respond angrily, lash out – झल्लाकर जवाब देना
61. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – indicate, show, highlight, mark, identify – इशारा करना
62. **Hoot** (verb) – shout, cheer, jeer, yell, laugh – ठहाका लगाना
63. **Nostalgic** (adjective) – sentimental, wistful, homesick, longing, reminiscent – पुरानी यादों से भरा
64. **Reminiscence** (noun) – memory, recollection, reflection, remembrance, flashback – स्मृति
65. **Let down** (phrasal verb) – disappoint, fail, dishearten, betray, discourage – निराश करना
66. **Cheerful** (adjective) – happy, joyful, lively, bright, jolly – खुशमिजाज

67. **Strange** (adjective) – unusual, odd, weird, peculiar, unfamiliar – अजीब
68. **Tattered** (adjective) – torn, ragged, shabby, frayed, worn-out – फटा हुआ
69. **Squeal** (verb) – scream, shriek, shout, yelp, cry – चिल्लाना
70. **Leap up** (phrasal verb) – jump up, rise suddenly, spring, bolt, bounce – उछल कर खड़ा होना
71. **Dangle** (verb) – hang, swing, suspend, droop, wave – झूलाना
72. **Rummage** (verb) – search, root around, dig, hunt, explore – खंगालना
73. **Grin** (verb) – smile broadly, beam, smirk, laugh, chuckle – मुस्कराना
74. **Distorted** (adjective) – twisted, warped, blurred, deformed, mangled – विकृत
75. **Fuss** (noun) – commotion, uproar, excitement, quarrel, worry – हंगामा
76. **Bathos** (noun) – anti-climax, disappointment, letdown, absurdity, descent – हास्यास्पद गिरावट
77. **Whodunit** (noun) – mystery, detective story, crime story, thriller, suspense – रहस्यकथा
78. **Confess** (verb) – admit, disclose, reveal, acknowledge, concede – स्वीकार करना
79. **Sheepish** (adjective) – embarrassed, awkward, shy, guilty, uneasy – शर्मिंदा
80. **Chuckle** (verb) – laugh quietly, giggle, snicker, smile, titter – धीमे से हँसना
81. **Merely** (adverb) – only, simply, just, barely, purely – मात्र

Practice Exercise



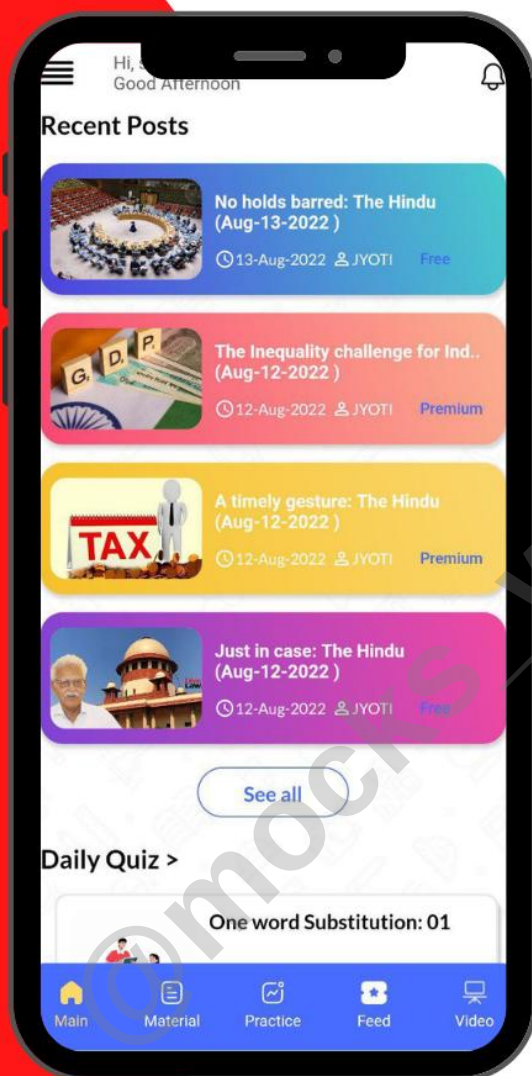
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